

DRAGON BALL Z

“It’s Over 9,000!”

WHEN WORLDVIEWS COLLIDE



FOREWORD BY
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Dragon Ball Z

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SAMPLE

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Foreword

For the role of Vegeta I'm lucky that I didn't have to go through an audition like I normally do. I was asked directly to do his voice and I am very thankful for that.

However, there was this issue where whenever Goku fought with an enemy character, usually that character died after 4 weeks. So I thought 'Okay, I guess this guy is gonna die in a few weeks too,' but I figured it would be better to give this character my best shot, to breathe life into Vegeta and make him the ultimate villain.

In Japanese there are many different ways of saying "I" and "You" (similar to saying thou, thee, or ye in English, but Japanese has way more and each of them are used in different situations), and I was careful not to use vulgar words that would make the character sound like some average villain. I intentionally used words that would sound more sophisticated yet intimidating, as a consummate villain should.

As for "Over 9,000!", to be honest, as a Japanese I'm not so sure what it is about that line that people like so much and why it became so popular, hahaha. In fact, I would have loved for someone to explain it to me like Derek does in this e-book.

But still, even though it was not my intention for that line to get so popular, me being the voice of that character, it makes me very happy that people enjoyed it so much.

I feel very honored and lucky that I had the chance to play Vegeta, a character that is loved by so many people around the world.

I am very grateful for that.

Ryo Horikawa

堀川りょう

2012

Introduction

The *Dragon Ball Z* internet phenomenon known as “It’s Over 9,000!” went viral with over 7 million views on YouTube in the late 2000’s. *Dragon Ball Z “It’s Over 9,000!” When Worldviews Collide* will explain the meaning behind “It’s Over 9,000!”, its significant pop cultural implications in mass media, and provide deep insights into what made the scene it’s based on so important.

If you have heard the term “It’s Over 9,000!” on the Internet or from somebody saying it in person, you may have laughed, been a bit confused, or started saying it yourself! In any case I can tell you with confidence that you’re still missing a lot of the story. In this e-book you’ll learn exactly *why* “It’s Over 9,000!” became so popular and you’ll discover what happens between two Saiya-jins when worldviews collide.

Part 1 “It’s Over 9,000!”

In Part 1 you will learn what “It’s Over 9,000!” is, where it originated, and how it became so popular in the modern pop cultural landscape.

Part 2 When Worldviews Collide: Goku versus Vegeta

Underlying themes prevalent in the *Dragon Ball Z* series make their debut in a meme. It is through scenes of conflict in characters that these themes come to life and engage the viewer. Two of the most prominent characters in the series, Goku and Vegeta, will be examined to show how their epic rivalry is a catalyst for profound growth.

Part 3 A Thin Slice of *Dragon Ball*

If “It’s Over 9,000!” represents a single letter of this evolving pop cultural language, than the *Dragon Ball* series embodies this unique alphabet. The significance lies in the community this creates, a language that is now understood by millions of fans that contribute to the identity of the collective and the individual.

The “It’s Over 9,000!” phenomenon is thus a microcosm of the epic *Dragon Ball* phenomenon. This e-book is just one of an even richer collection of stories that are further revealed in *The Dao of Dragon Ball* book.

The journey of “Over 9,000” miles starts with a single turn of the page.

PART 1 “It’s Over 9,000!”

Dragon Ball Z is an extremely influential Japanese anime and pop culture success. The action packed television series reached its peak in Japan from 1990 to 1996 and in the United States from 1999 to 2003. This e-book gives an inside look into how one viewer transformed a typical *Dragon Ball Z* episode into a shorter clip that exploded in popularity on YouTube, receiving over 7 million views. The content of this video inspired a common pop culture Internet joke, or *meme*, called “It’s over 9,000!” that spread around the world.

In episode 21 of *Dragon Ball Z*, Vegeta and Nappa, the two Saiya-jin aliens, have invaded Earth seeking the dragon balls so that they can have their wish for immortality granted by Shenron (Chinese: *Shenlong*, 神龍), the God Dragon. Goku, the hero of the series, stands in their way, and they want to determine Goku’s battle power before they fight.

Vegeta uses his “Scouter” (Japanese: *Sukautā*, スカウター), an advanced energy-detecting device that tracks the number of an opponent’s battle power level. Vegeta watches Goku’s number increase rapidly as it rises up to power level 8,000 and then to over 9,000. Vegeta screams, “It’s over 9,000!” and breaks his Scouter in rage.

Over nine years after its premiere in the United States, a humorously edited video of this segment was placed on YouTube and went viral. Through social media, “It’s over 9,000!” became a popular meme and is now a global Internet term that people use to describe anything of high quantity.

This e-book explains the “It’s over 9,000!” phenomenon.

The Original “It’s Over 9,000!”

To better understand the “It’s over 9,000!” phenomenon, we have to review the source material that was used to create it. Namely, the episode that the clip was taken from.

In the original *Dragon Ball Z* episode, the Saiya-jins, Nappa and Vegeta, threaten Earth’s people and have already caused great damage. Up to this point in time Goku has been training in the afterlife with the celestial being, North Kaiō. After hastily returning to Earth, Goku speeds toward the battleground hoping that he can make it in time.

When Goku arrives, he sees that many of his allies and lifelong friends have already died in the battle, and he is extremely upset at the news. He “powers up” with anger and prepares for the fight.

The environment around Goku begins to react to his incredible energy. Vegeta’s Scouter picks up on Goku’s

rising energy and begins making noises while flashing numbers on the panel in front of his eyes.

The original scene of the American English dub occurs in episode 21 of the first season of *DBZ*, first aired on April 26, 1997. Here is the dialogue:

Goku: "GREAAAAAARRRGHHH!" *Powers up.*

Vegeta: "Power level's ... 8,000. Huh? Now, it's over nine."

Goku: "YEAAAAAAGHHH!" *Finishes powering up. The rocks levitating in the air fall down and the dust clears.*

Nappa: "Vegeta, what does the Scouter say about his power level?"

Vegeta: *Takes the Scouter off his head. "It's over 9,000!" Crushes the Scouter in his hand.*

Nappa: "What, 9,000?! There's no way that can be right, can it?!"

That's the entire scene. It was just one of many in the 508 episodes of the *Dragon Ball* series and warranted no special attention or recognition.

However, nine years later, an edited version was created by a YouTube user, Kajetokun, and posted on October 17, 2006, called "9000!! NINE THOUSAAAAANDD!" This innocuous 30-second clip was looped continuously, chopped up, slowed down, sped up, and made into a highly comedic two-and-a-half-minute-long video.¹ The original post on YouTube received over 5 million views as of June 28, 2009, and continued to spread globally. As of June 29, 2012, the original "It's over 9,000!" video by Kajetokun had over 7.1 million views.

During the rise of the meme's popularity, the Japanator website interviewed Kajetokun on April 30, 2008. Kajetokun said, "I had no idea it was going to get this big. Really, it was just a small little something I made as an inside joke for my friends. My friend Patrick posted it on [4Chan.org's] /b/, and then I ended up having, like, 20,000 views the next day. Then Scott from VGCats.com front page linked [to] my video, and I woke up to 200,000 views." It started to rise considerably from that point on.

As a result of its popularity, a previously nonexistent term became a searchable phrase. According to Google Trends, search queries in the last quarter of 2008 for the shortened term "over 9000" rose steeply, especially during the week of September 22.

The video was subsequently remixed, spoofed, and transformed by others, and it took on a life of its own. Live-action scenes were filmed, 3D models were rendered, and random combinations of different versions from various sources have been thrown together all over the Web.

1 See the Resources page at the end of this e-book for links to the videos.

For those unfamiliar with the series, the scene may not make any sense when taken out of context. However, the meme connected with non-*Dragon Ball Z* viewers in the humorous way that it was replicated, which was a significant reason why it caught on like wildfire.

This creative act of sharing through social media resulted in something quite interesting. The video reached a new demographic of Internet-savvy users previously unfamiliar with Japanese anime, introducing *Dragon Ball Z* to millions more.

The Original “Over 9,000!” Was Really “Over 8,000!”

For most casual viewers unfamiliar with the Japanese version, they would have no idea that the term “Over 9,000!” was wrong to begin with. But it was! In the original Japanese anime, manga, and newly “refreshed” version of *Dragon Ball Z* (known as *Dragon Ball Kai*) Goku’s power level was specifically stated as being “Over 8,000!”

In episode 28 of the Japanese *DBZ* anime (aired November 29, 1989) and episode 12 of the *Kai* anime series (aired June 21, 2009), the scene proceeds as follows:

Goku: “YEAAAAAARRRRGGHHHH!” *Powers up.*

Vegeta: “Battle power is 7,000 ... 8,000 ... Impossible!”

Goku: “YEARGHHH!” *Finishes powering up. The rocks levitating in the air fall down and the dust clears.*

Nappa: “Vegeta! What’s the reading on Kakarotto’s battle power now?”²

Vegeta: *Takes the Scouter off his head. “It’s over 8,000!” Crushes the Scouter in his hand.*

Nappa: “Over 8,000?! There must be some mistake! It must be broken!”

Why the difference in translation for the English anime?

The common answer available on the Internet is that the anime was dubbed in English as “9,000” because the sound of “nine” worked better with Vegeta’s mouth movements than “eight.” This seems plausible because dubbing companies frequently replace lines with ones they feel are more appropriate or synchronize better

² Kakarotto (Kakarot in the FUNimation dub) is Goku’s original Saiya-jin name before being adopted and raised on earth. Vegeta and Nappa only refer to Goku with his Saiya-jin name.

with the animation.

However, if you look at the actual animation, this isn't so plausible. The mouth movements are simple and both "eight" and "nine" could have been vocalized by the shape of Vegeta's mouth. So it is unclear why the change was made, and it could have possibly just been a mistake.

What is interesting is that years later, in 2004, during a redubbing of *Dragon Ball Z*'s early episodes, the supposed mistake was replicated. FUNimation had years of experience with the series at this point and should have been fully aware of the original Japanese phrase, voiced by Ryo Horikawa. Nevertheless, their *Ultimate Uncut Edition* DVDs repeated the "It's over 9,000!" line with their own cast, with Vegeta played by Christopher Sabat. But fans were not as happy with this rendition as they were with the video clip used by Kajetokun in the original video, where Vegeta was played by Brian Drummond of the Ocean Group voice acting company from Canada. The reason most often given by fans for this preference is that they prefer Drummond's over-the-top extension of "nine thousaaaaandd." Similarly edited "It's over 9,000!" clips using the FUNimation actors were not as popular.

As time passed and the fandom for "It's over 9,000!" grew, FUNimation became very familiar with the meme. They capitalized on it to promote their *Dragon Box* releases of the *Dragon Ball Z* series in 2009. The promotional trailer was narrated by Christopher Sabat as Vegeta, who said, "Can you feel the *Dragon Box*'s power? It's over 9,000!"

Because *Dragon Ball* kept being rereleased in different formats, in 2010, FUNimation redubbed the scene in English once again for the "refreshed" *Dragon Ball Z Kai*. But this time they dubbed two versions. In the televised version, Vegeta said "It's over 9,000!" while on the uncut DVDs he said "It's over 8,000!" FUNimation was well aware of the meme's popularity in society and wanted the public to be happy, so they redubbed it incorrectly on purpose because it was so popularly accepted to be "It's over 9,000!" rather than "It's over 8,000!" The DVD buyers were a smaller and more hard-core audience that FUNimation believed would prefer the proper "It's over 8,000!" Yet this caused a problem, as some of the fans actually wanted it to be "It's over 9,000!" because of their adoration for the meme.

This means that FUNimation, one of the largest anime and voice-over companies in the world, changed the way they did business in order to ride the wave of the "It's over 9,000!" meme's success. They were influenced by a *Dragon Ball* Internet meme created by a single person's video that went viral.

The fact that FUNimation successfully dubbed the line as "It's over 8,000!" shatters the argument that it was impossible for Vegeta to say "8,000" because of the mouth movements. They could have done it before in the original dub, but if they had, then we wouldn't have the term "It's over 9,000!" today!

“Over 9,000!” of *What*?

What does “It’s over 9,000!” even mean? Nine thousand of what?

If you watch the video or read the manga, you’ll see a unique-looking device attached to the side of Vegeta’s head, called the Scouter. The Saiya-jin use the Scouter to detect and quantify a living being’s combined physical, emotional, and spiritual energy at a given time.

Scouters are used immediately after landing on a planet to scout the locations of possible threats or targets of attack, such as powerful warriors or cities filled with people. How and what type of energy frequency it analyzes is unspecified, as is the unit of measurement. Supposedly it detects a life frequency, known in Japanese as *ki*, and translates this into a number, which the *Dragon Ball* warriors in the original Japanese refer to as *sentō-ryoku* (戦闘力). The term can be translated into English as “combat power,” “fighting strength,” “battle power” or “power level.”

This *ki* (気, pronounced “kee”) is a Japanese term for a universal life force believed to be found in all beings, and one that can be developed and strengthened through training. In East Asian martial arts and medical theories, *ki* is found in every cell of the untold billions within the body, as well as in the combined life experience and spiritual energy of the being. The greater the life force (*ki*), the greater the power level.

Ki is paradoxically both an ephemeral, invisible energy, as well as a material, visible substance. Not all people can feel or see it. Through training in special exercise and meditation regimens, it is generally believed that a person can become increasingly sensitive to *ki*. It has electric, warm, magnetic qualities, described as heat, wind, or perceived as light, and it can push, pull, or flow like water. It is also related to a person’s inner spirit and mood. In this sense, *ki* is a material substance, a life force, and an energy form all in one.

All beings in *Dragon Ball* have *ki* and it is simply a matter of training hard to develop it. After a certain point of training, this energy can be projected out of the body as a material weapon or in various other ways, such as self powered flight.

For reference, in *Dragon Ball*, the overweight yet physically active farmer at the beginning of *Dragon Ball Z* had a power level of 5 before being killed by Goku’s brother, Raditz, who had a power level of approximately 1,200.

Why Is Power Level Important?

Aside from using it when sizing up their opponents, Saiya-jins use power level to determine the relative strength of their own children at birth so as to classify them within their caste-based social order. Since they are a warrior race, this is how they determine who is valuable and who is not.

Vegeta and Nappa were both born into royal families. Vegeta informs Goku that he was born into a low caste and sent off to another planet because of his low power level. Vegeta is the royal prince and strongest of his race, and Nappa is the general of the entire Saiya-jin army. The fact that Goku, a low-caste Saiya-jin, now has a power level over 8,000 is a slap in the face to Vegeta and Nappa.

Nappa has a power level of 4,000 and Vegeta has a power level of 18,000. This is why Nappa freaks out while Goku remains confident. It's why Vegeta is so upset and screams "It's over 8,000!" and then smashes his Scouter. Vegeta isn't afraid, he's just especially surprised and annoyed by Goku's rapid growth, because less than a year earlier, Goku had a power level of only 334 while fighting against Raditz. And how could a low-class Saiya-jin have such power? Goku's incredible change was a result of his training in the afterlife with North Kaiō, master of the northern quadrant of the universe.

In *Dragon Ball Kai*, Nappa gets beaten down and punched into a small mountain by Goku. He yells, "Damn you to Hell!" to which Goku calmly responds, "I see now. As expected, you're not that tough." Nappa shouts back, "I'm an elite warrior from a noble family! I won't allow some low-class trash like you to make fun of nobility like me! You're gonna' pay! I'll freakin' kill you!" Nappa's self image and pride are threatened by Goku's existence, and in order to validate himself, Nappa has to kill this "low-class trash." In *Dragon Ball Z*, a warrior's pride becomes a matter of life and death.

...

End of Part 1 Sample

Yet there's more to the "Over 9,000!" story than meets the eye. In Part 2 of this e-book you'll discover how the scene between Goku and Vegeta was the result of their different worldviews colliding, the prelude to an epic rivalry, and the fundamental source of their growth.

PART 2 When Worldviews Collide: Goku versus Vegeta

The “It’s over 9,000!” video seems simple and humorous, but there’s much more going on behind the scenes than the viewer may be aware of. Part of the popularity of “It’s over 9,000!” stems from an underlying theme present throughout *Dragon Ball*—the power of an individual’s untapped potential—which manifests in clashing worldviews, conflict and polar character development.

Considering that both Goku and Vegeta are full blooded Saiya-jins, why do they oppose one another? In order to fully understand why the scene depicted in “It’s over 9,000!” is so important, we need to delve into the two worldviews and the warriors they produced.

In Part 2 you will learn how “It’s over 9,000!” shows the dichotomy between worldviews colliding and points to several underlying themes inherent in *Dragon Ball Z* and our own humanity.

You will see that it’s not as simple as “good guy” fights “bad guy.” You’re about to discover exactly why Goku and Vegeta were destined for conflict and why the scene depicted in “It’s over 9,000!” is such an important part of the *Dragon Ball* story.

2.1 Growth through Conflict

There is no growth without conflict. And there is no greater conflict in story telling than an ideological, class-based, external vs. internal, hard vs. soft, fist-to-fist brawl! It is through conflict that Goku and Vegeta are able to increase their power level and refine their character.

The primary cause of conflict in *Dragon Ball* comes from differences in ideological mindsets, whether it’s the difference between the Turtle School and Crane School ethics or Piccolo Daimao’s desire to conquer the Earth and Goku’s decision to stop him. These worldviews collide and cause violent, combative conflicts.

The original *Dragon Ball* is a mix of fantastical Kung Fu legends with Japanese and American pop culture. *Dragon Ball Z* introduces aliens into the fold, complicating things further. At this point it shifts from different factions on Earth fighting against one another, to all of Earth united against an alien threat. There are now two worldviews in conflict—earthlings who believe in a person’s inner potential, and aliens who judge a person at birth.

On Earth, everyone is born more or less equal and has the potential to rise up and shape their own lives. A person is not limited by their genetics. Earthlings judge others by their actions, and the spiritual warriors on

Earth intuitively feel the power of others expressed at any given moment, whether it's positive or negative. They look upon others holistically and understand that everyone has ups and downs, like a wave, so it is important to see past current behaviors and believe in their potential.

In contrast, the aliens believe that people are fixed at birth and will amount to nothing more than what they start with. There is no amount of hard work that can overcome their classification. The Saiya-jins have an altogether different worldview from the earthlings because theirs is a paradigm built on social structure maintained through power: Where strength is all that matters. The Saiya-jin society was assimilated by Lord Freeza when he subjugated their civilization. He placed their already power based social framework into an even larger power based social hierarchy, with himself at the top. Suddenly the Saiya-jins not only had to compete with themselves for the position of top monkey, but also the other aliens and mutants within the Empire. It's a place where life and death are determined by power level alone, measured and judged by an external scientific device called the Scouter.

The universal life energy called *ki* bonds these two worldviews together. Daoism and East Asian martial arts state that *ki* is found in all forms of matter throughout the universe and can be cultivated by anyone. Both cultures use their own form of mind-body science to develop and refine *ki*. *Ki* is a subtle language that everyone understands, yet they understand it in different ways owing to their different self-cultivation systems.

In the case of Goku and Vegeta, not only are they both *ki* cultivation practitioners, they're also full blooded Saiya-jins. They love to fight, push themselves in extreme challenges and almost die in the process, only to rise up stronger. Deep in their Saiya-jin sub-conscious there is no greater joy or purpose in life. Nevertheless, they are completely different in how they view themselves and others.

The significance of the "It's over 9,000!" scene lies in how it exposes these worldviews through conflict.

Let's start by turning our eye toward Vegeta, the Prince of all Saiya-jins.

2.2 Vegeta's Perspective - Through the Lens of a Scouter

Vegeta's worldview is the result of being raised in a power struggle society built atop the fusion of external scientific technology and mind-body science.

This e-book isn't about summarizing the entire history of Saiya-jin society or of Vegeta's life. For that you can go to the Internet or the series itself. Instead, here's the short version of the parts that formed Vegeta's worldview.

The Saiya-jins (the vegetable people) originally lived on Planet Plant with the Tsufuru-jins (the fruit people).¹

1 The Japanese term *Tsufuru-jin* (ツフル人) is a name pun by Toriyama, referencing the English word of fruit, transliterated as *furutsu* and rearranged. The name humorously contrasts the *Saiya-jin* (サイヤ人), an-

The Saiya-jins were strong but barbaric and the Tsufuru-jins were physically weak yet highly scientific. There was a 10 year war and the vegetables proved stronger than the fruits. The Tsufuru-jins were annihilated and the Saiya-jins renamed it Planet Vegeta, in honor of King Vegeta, father of Prince Vegeta.

Afterward, their undeveloped society was assimilated into the Freeza Empire under the promise that they would be taken care of and allowed to battle new opponents all over the galaxy, forever enjoying their lives as warriors.² The remaining technology of the Tsufuru-jins was assimilated into the Freeza Empire, including the Scouters they used in battle.

The Scouter would ironically become synonymous with the Saiya-jins themselves, even though their original nature (before meeting Freeza) was to abhor technology and rely exclusively on their own internal strength. They are introduced in the series wearing Scouters, so the audience associates them with the device, but it does not originate from their own culture.

Why is that important to “It’s over 9,000!”? Because what the Saiya-jins actually received was subjugation under a despotic overlord: A being who told them what to do, what planet to conquer and who to fight. Freeza was so concerned that the Saiya-jin’s incredible fighting potential may get out of control that he analyzed their powers at birth in order to maintain his dominance. All the while this despot profited at their expense and offered no alternative other than death.

Freeza created a society where scientists measure a person’s power level with an external device to determine their internal worth. Every Saiya-jin is subjected to this test. The ones with a passing grade are allowed to stay and placed into an appropriate class. Vegeta for example had a high power level at birth and is a self-declared “super elite.” Those at the other end of the spectrum are considered social trash and sent to outlying planets with the intent that they would grow up, become strong, and kill everyone, making the planet easier for Freeza’s men to conquer and sell. This is Goku; a disposable piece of garbage sent to cleanse Earth.

In a class based society like Freeza’s, people don’t have the opportunity to live up to their potential. No other characteristic of a person’s mind is important in this society. Will they be talented artists? Are they compassionate listeners or soulful singers? It doesn’t matter. All that matters is one’s power level at birth measured by the Scouter. This isn’t to say Freeza’s society doesn’t have scientists or intelligent thinkers, because we see that there are medics, pilots and other engineers, but in a military based society filled with warriors, the intelligentsia are merely the oil used to keep the war machine running.

other rearranged name pun referencing the Japanese word for vegetable, *yasai*. The FUNimation dub refers to their race as Tuffles, which is a play on the fungi called truffles. It is not common knowledge that truffles are the “fruit body” of the fungi, so this unfortunately dilutes the humorous dichotomy between the two opposing races on Planet Plant that Toriyama intended.

² There is no official name for the Freeza Empire in the original Japanese, so “Freeza Empire” is a term born out of necessity. Nevertheless, foreign fans have unofficially (and debatably) referred to it as the “Planet Trade Organization” or “World Trade Organization,” as it is in the business of cleansing and selling planets. Surprisingly such a business transaction is never shown in the series, only referred to by Raditz and others as their *raison d’etre*.

Freeza viewed the Saiya-jins as menial servants, and the Saiya-jins were kept blissfully ignorant of their situation. Under false pretense they did Freeza's grunt work for little more than their own survival, and yet many of them believed in the illusion and were grateful for it. Their basic needs were being met and their Saiya-jin desire to fight and kill was being satiated. Seemed like a good deal.

Truthfully, the Saiya-jins experienced segregation based on a number that in practice is no different than segregation by skin color or any other external factor. Freeza disliked the Saiya-jins for being savages and he feared their power in numbers, but he gladly took advantage of their desire to fight. He skillfully maintained the illusion that they were better off than before by rewarding them with feelings of accomplishment, such as a higher rank in the army with more responsibility. Freeza harnessed their primal strength through this external form of psychological manipulation.

The illusion was that they could somehow improve their lives within Freeza's hierarchy, but it was a lie from the beginning because they were judged through the lens of a Scouter and classified at birth. A man's entire identity was fixed, static and unchanging.

It was slavery. Freeza was a foreigner who annexed the natives from their home, gave them technology and put them to work for nothing more than food, shelter, and a false sense of purpose.

Whether intentional by Akira Toriyama or not, it's easy to see the correlations between this story and our own world history. Freeza, a white alien, profited off the sweat and blood of what he often described as "monkeys," by promising a better future in a new frontier.

The class structure concept was a fabricated paradigm used to enforce his will on others and maintain power. It's a social and behavioral framework that is all too relatable, and it's one that all Saiya-jins went along with. The groupthink mentality towed the line of the status quo or the complicit will of King Vegeta. And according to Freeza, "high class" or not, they were still just "filthy monkeys."

By the time King Vegeta enlightened to his reality and decided to rebel against his "master," it was too late. The beginning of the Saiya-jin persecution and the end for the Saiya-jin race had already begun.

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2.2.2 Human Nature in Action

It is human nature to categorize. Seemingly embedded in our genetic code is the intrinsic need to quantify and measure our reality to then find our place in it and navigate around. It helps us make sense of the world. This is exactly why the Saiya-jins and other aliens within Freeza's empire use the Scouter to navigate new worlds and encounters.

The psychologist William James states in *The Varieties of Religious Experience: A Study in Human Nature* (1902), “The first thing an intellect does with an object is to classify it along with something else.” As children we learn to categorize the objects around us. An apple is a fruit, a flower is a plant, a dog is an animal. Likewise as adults we first categorize people and places, and only then do we know how to interact. For example, the social responses we give to an animal are far different than to a gentleman. Observing differences among people and categorizing them (or choosing not to) is what leads to the development of a unique worldview.

Try to imagine living in a society like Vegeta’s where power is all that matters and self worth is defined by a number. All the warriors identify or interact with others with their own number and the number of the other person in mind. The first thing they do when they meet someone new is measure them with the Scouter. Likewise, the first thing they do after landing on a new planet is check the Scouter for high power levels. It is a habitual, reflexive action.

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Even Goku’s father cared nothing for his son. In *Dragon Ball Z: Bardock, The Father of Goku* TV Special (1990), his squad mates ask Bardock if he would like to go back to Planet Vegeta and visit his newborn child. Bardock says “To see the lowest-class warrior without any promise at all? What kind of fool would make that trip?” This is what the Scouter does, it strips people of their worth and turns them into a number. A society built upon these numbers denies its own humanity. How fitting that in *Dragon Ball* this society consists of aliens and mutants. There is no “human” among them.

It also tells us that if we only pay attention to that which is measurable through external instruments, then we’ll become blind to the wonders of potential and possibility in all that isn’t. In life, what you see matters much less than how you see it. Worldviews change the reality of what one perceives and responds to. Conflicts arise when worldviews collide and one person isn’t able to let go of their notions or expectations built up by the perceptions they created over time. For example, Vegeta uses the Scouter’s numbers to validate his own self-worth and invalidate others. He thinks of himself as the greatest and everyone else as worthless trash, *including* those who are more powerful because his father taught him that he is a superior being. Are they really trash, or is that label due to his perception?

Vegeta is the product of his environment. He was born a Saiya-jin and prone to ruthless fighting, but his upbringing made him even more violent, compassionless, selfish, and angry. These characteristics are evident throughout his entire life, and as he rises up he pushes others down in order to validate his own ego. A stark contrast to Goku.

2.3 Goku’s Perspective - Earthlings and Inner Development

As full blooded Saiya-jins, Goku and Vegeta share similar genetic nature, but their environmental nurture is what separates them. How is this possible? Why is Goku so different?

Like Vegeta, Goku takes hardship as joy. He loves facing a strong opponent and pushing himself to surpass his limits. They both thrive in that environment. They crave it. But Goku has a childhood that completely changed his personality and worldview from that of a normal Saiya-jin, and particularly in contrast to Vegeta. Goku represents the opposite of everything that Vegeta stands for.

Consider that at birth, Kakarot (Goku's given name) was scientifically gauged by Scouter technology to have a battle power so low relative to other Saiya-jins that he was discarded altogether from their society. In *Dragon Ball Z: Bardock, The Father of Goku* TV Special (1990), a nursing ward technician says, "Yeah, he's definitely the kid of a lower class warrior. He's barely got any potential ability at all. The best we can do with him is send him off to one of the frontier planets." It's later shown in Bardock's Scouter that he has a power level of 2. This is why he was sent through space and landed on Earth. Kakarot was the last son of Planet Vegeta.

Think about this crucial scene for a moment. Kakarot was being placed into a Saiya-jin space pod so he could be sent to some far off planet. At the same time his father was single handedly rebelling against Freeza and his men. Bardock's attack was futile, and as Freeza's massive *ki* ball ripped through his body, a sleeping baby blasted off the launch pad on his way to Earth. The *ki* ball landed on Planet Vegeta, penetrated its core, and catastrophically annihilated it, along with the entire Saiya-jin race. Bardock was killed and Planet Vegeta was gone, along with the Saiya-jin race. Vegeta was forced to experience the loss of his father, his planet and his people. Kakarot was a Saiya-jin but he knew nothing of what that meant. Kakarot's mind was empty, and because of that, it was able to be filled.

The child was adopted by an elderly martial arts master named Son Gohan who loved him as if he were his own. With his Saiya-jin nature the child was unusually powerful, uncontrollable, and wanted nothing to do with Son Gohan's kindness. One day while walking around the mountainside, the child pulled himself out of Son Gohan's makeshift baby basket as he reached for a fruit hanging on a tree branch, and fell into a deep ravine. He fell from such great heights that it would have killed a human child, but all he got was a nasty bump on the head. Even so, as a result of hitting his head on the hardened exposed roots of a tree he completely lost all knowledge of self. His rambunctious, violent Saiya-jin attitude was gone, replaced with a care free, wide eyed and happy go lucky mindset. "Grandpa" Gohan raised him up to the blue, empty sky, and seeing his big smiling face, decided to name him Son Goku (孫悟空)—A Buddhist name that means "The Child Aware of Emptiness."³

Goku is raised as an earthling and grows up in the wilderness atop Mt. Paozu, with only a small hermit hut as a home, which he shares with Gohan. Uneducated and simple minded, he knows little about technology and a lot about living in accordance with nature. He fishes with his hands and feet. He chops wood the same way. He avoids using external tools unless he has to and is completely unfamiliar with electronics. The first time he meets Bulma he thinks that she's a monster because she's inside a car. After she gets out, he then decides that the car is a monster and she's a witch.

Goku has a simple mindset because he lives in a simple, ancient way, far removed from the complications of

3 Son Goku (孫悟空) can also be translated as "Grandson Awake to Vacuity," "Baby who Apprehends the Void," or "Young Boy Enlightened to Emptiness."

society. The only technology he learns to use frequently is the Dragon Radar, and that's just so he can find the dragon balls. Goku is a feral child. A mountain boy. A country bumpkin with an accent.

Goku's character development is inspired by Eastern origins as a literary descendent of Sun Wukong (孫悟空) from *Journey to the West* (Chinese: *xīyóujì*, 西遊記, Japanese: *saikyūki*, 西遊記), a 16th century Chinese legend featuring Buddhist and Daoist belief systems. Goku's perspective is founded on the metaphysical beliefs of traditional East Asian culture: A respectful alignment with nature and faith in human potential. He is broad minded, compassionate and self-reliant because this is what those belief systems espouse. Buddhist Law practices teach that all beings have "Buddha Nature." The Great Dao teachings express that all things are "One," and that as humans we are part of "The Way" and should live in accordance with nature. Goku becomes a product of this environment and lives these beliefs.

By nature Goku is a Saiya-jin, but by nurture he is a native earthling taught by hermit masters in traditional mind-body concepts and who grew up in the wild outdoors. Rather than use an external scientific device to harshly judge others, he is taught by kind hearted warriors to internally "feel" his opponents' subtle energy.

Goku learns to feel the energy of his opponents because he develops this skill while ascending the spiritual ladder with Son Gohan, Kame Sennin, Karin, Mister Popo, Kami and North Kaiō as his masters. It was gained through physical hardship combined with stillness in meditation. His true self is nurtured until the false self (the ego) is let go and his true self and the world unite. He can feel all living creatures, including the birds, fish, plants, other people and even planets. His mind is broad, and the concepts he was taught are totally different from the aliens who destroy anyone that doesn't comply with their notions and who grow up surrounded by scientific gadgets. Goku is a spiritual warrior because of the men who raised him.

2.3.1 Believing Before Seeing

Why is Goku taught this way? Because traditional East Asian self-cultivation practices teach that a normal person will only believe what they can see with their own two eyes while a supernormal person will believe it before they see it. Belief is a prerequisite to seeing. Because the normal person allows their eyes to be shrouded by the illusion of this physical world, they are blind to the truths at higher levels and won't believe in them. These people are said to have poor enlightenment quality (Chinese: *wuxing*, 悟性), are lacking in wisdom, and are blind to the hidden potential inside all beings. The first character in *wuxing* is also the first in Goku's name (*wu* is pronounced *go* in Japanese), which symbolizes that Goku can perceive what others cannot.

The Western (or from a Japanese perspective, foreign) way of thinking is more externally accurate, with precise scientifically derived statistics independent of the situation, while the East Asian way of thinking is amorphous, with greater dependence on situational context. In such a paradigm the numbers and specifics become less important, with the emphasis instead on the intuitive nuances and emotion of the moment—the same way that it isn't absolutely necessary to be accurate when saying "It's over 9,000!" in real life when you mean "a lot." It's more about the feeling or heart of something rather than its precise external manifestation

seen by the physical eyes.

Instead of relying on their own intuition and having compassion for others, these normal people rely on a set of external tools, whether that is the lenses of their own eyes or an additional external lens (such as the Scouter), to perceive the world. They only believe in quantifiable facts, the hard reality, and cannot see beyond themselves and their precious numbers. And that's because they're looking externally to begin with, and it's much easier to point the finger at someone or something else, instead of pointing inward.

As a Japanese author, Akira Toriyama writes to a Japanese audience and references East Asian culture. He makes the reader feel that Goku is the home team hero they should cheer for. To the Japanese readers Goku arguably appears Japanese, speaks with a countryside Japanese accent and his martial arts techniques are written in the more local and softer looking *hiragana* alphabet with occasional *kanji*. His association with legendary supernormal elements from the eastern fable *Journey to the West*, such as the Daoist magic cloud called *kinto'un* (English: Flying Nimbus), and his Buddhist magic staff, the *nyoibo* (English: Power Pole) strengthen this association. His insistence on referring to himself as Goku, a Japanese Buddhist name given to him on Earth, while Vegeta insists on calling him Kakarot, a name given to him on Planet Vegeta, strengthens this association even further. Goku is the modern illustrated personification of thousands of years of traditional East Asian culture, embodied as one character.

Goku is a native earthling while Vegeta is a foreign alien. To make the dichotomy even more apparent, Toriyama differentiates their clothing (Goku wears traditional martial arts uniform while Vegeta wears advanced battle armor) and hair (Goku's hair is broad while Vegeta's is straight up). To the Japanese, foreign terms, including those transliterated from English, are usually written in *katakana*. Toriyama further emphasizes the difference by writing most of Vegeta's techniques in the *katakana* alphabet, derived from English, such as Final Flash (Japanese: *Fainaru Furasshu*, ファイナルフラッシュ), and Big Bang Attack (Japanese: *Biggu Ban Atakku*, ビッグバンアタック). Likewise Scouters (Japanese: *Sukautā*, スカウター) and their Saiya-jin names, Vegeta (Japanese: *Bejīta*, ベジータ) and Kakarot (Japanese: *Kakarotto*, カカロット).

Most importantly, Goku is taught to believe in the potential of others before he sees their potential realized while Vegeta is taught to believe that no one has potential and should be killed when no longer useful. Goku believes before he sees, which becomes a quintessential aspect of his character.

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2.3.3 He Who Conquers Himself

The Daoist patriarch Laozi is credited with saying, "He who conquers others is strong. He who conquers himself is mighty." Simply put, Goku fights to improve himself and raise his abilities because it makes him feel stronger and happy. He has internal confidence and doesn't care about power levels. He doesn't need a number to validate his own self-worth. Goku seeks stronger opponents to push himself farther and prove that

he is stronger than he was before, not to validate his own existence and invalidate theirs, as Vegeta does.

Generally speaking, the villainous characters want to be better than everyone else, while the good natured characters just want to be better than themselves. Of course not all of the good guys start out that way. Many of them are selfish in the beginning, but the more time they spend around Goku the more they change. By the end of the series, the majority align themselves with Goku's perspective and become spiritual warriors just like him. And why not? Without his selfless actions they wouldn't even be alive. Most importantly, Goku is the one striving for *self*-superiority and he is the one who truly achieves it. All of the others improve and learn more about themselves because they're trying to catch up to him.

Goku's life runs counter to Saiya-jin culture. Goku is hopeful that others can change, and that's because he himself is a person who changes! It's in-character for him to offer hope and redemption, because he first offers hope and redemption to himself. He wouldn't rise up as quickly as he did if he didn't think that way. He is as Vegeta described in *Dragon Ball Z* episode 280, "a kind hearted Saiya-jin."

Thus, Goku is the manifest opposite of what Vegeta believes Saiya-jin culture and its people represent. To Vegeta, Goku's very existence is a slap in the face and an insult to his pride, the source of his strength.

And that is why they clash.

2.4 Vegeta Clashes with Others

Vegeta's clashes with others are about telling the story of his personal development. His battles before Goku have little meaning except to demonstrate his desire to dominate over others. However, his battle with Goku and those after Goku mark a shift in his story. His worldview starts to crumble away, piece by piece, forever changing his character and providing one of the most interesting personality changes in the history of anime. The moment Vegeta screamed "It's over 9,000!" and broke that scouter is the moment his life began to change.

Through successive battles he goes from a proud, egotistical, Scouter reliant man like any other in the Freeza Empire, to humiliated and vengeful. Finally letting go of his Scouter, Vegeta learns to rely on his own intuition and inner strength to enact revenge. At every step he breaks down another mental wall built up to protect himself, and by doing so he taps into more potential and increases his power level.

The battle between Goku and Vegeta changed both their lives. To see how, we have to look at what Vegeta was like before the two actually made physical contact.

Remember that Goku had just broken Nappa's spine and paralyzed him from the waist down. What does Vegeta do with his partner and fellow Saiya-jin, a man who helped raise and protect him? A man who understood him better than anyone?

He kills him!

He picks Nappa up by the hand, flings him into the sky, and hits him with a *ki* blast that causes his body to explode into nothingness. That's how little Vegeta cared for Nappa. He saw Nappa as a tool that performed his bidding, and when that tool was exhausted he threw it out like a piece of trash. Vegeta did this because according to his mindset Nappa no longer had any value and might as well be discarded. Freeza set the precedent of treating others this way and Vegeta followed it.

Suffice to say that Vegeta loses the fight against Goku and his friends, not because of a lack in power, ability, or intensity. Rather because he lacks insight and can't see past himself. He judges Goku and says that he's "low class" trash. He relies on the Scouter to validate his own superiority. He kills his own partner after standing on the sidelines and letting him do all the preliminary work. Vegeta is very much like Sun Wukong from *Journey to the West*, in that he gladly fights alone against superior numbers, filled with pride and the belief that he is stronger than the gods, more powerful than the "Will of Heaven" and even the Buddha. Sun Wukong is the character Son Goku is named after, but Vegeta inherited his cocky attitude.

Vegeta's fight against Goku represents a collision of external scientific technology versus internal spiritual beliefs, class versus classless, and individualism versus relationships. Despite Vegeta's strengths, his internal character flaws cause him to lose the fight all the same, and it's because the earthlings had spiritual warrior training, didn't think in terms of class, and worked together as friends.

At the end of the fight Vegeta crawls away as a bloody mess and tries to climb into his Saiya-jin space pod. Krillin holds Yajirobe's katana to Vegeta's face and is about to deliver the death blow.

But Goku stops him.

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2.4.1 The Evolving Eyes of a Super Elite

Vegeta changes after fighting Goku. The first of these many changes was his newfound ability to look within, to have insight and the intuitive ability to control and sense power levels *without* a Scouter.

Perhaps because he was faced with an overwhelming case of reality in the form of defeat, Vegeta makes the decision to change and grow. He lets go of his reliance on the external Scouter and instead relies on his own internal ability. He's still a ruthless murderer, mind you, but he has gained the ability to regulate his power. This is the sole reason why he survives as long as he does on Planet Namek. If he took the easier way out and chose to stay the same as the other aliens, then he would have continued to see the world in the same light that they do.

Let's take a moment to examine Vegeta's life after Goku.

So Vegeta had just lost the fight and escaped in his Saiya-jin space pod. He lands on Planet Freeza 79 at a military base, where his wounds are healed. He learns that Freeza has traveled to Planet Namek to gather the dragon balls and wish for immortality. Vegeta becomes furious and chases after him so he can gather the dragon balls first and wish for his own immortality, thus gaining the power to enact sweet revenge.

Vegeta initially still uses the Scouter out of old habit, but quickly lets it go after realizing just how talented he really is. The proof he needed came in the form of an old rival within the Freeza Empire, named Kui, who likewise chased Vegeta to Planet Namek in order to kill him. They had a longstanding rivalry.

After landing, Kui locates Vegeta with his Scouter and flies to his location. Because Kui believes his power level is superior, he issues a challenge.

Kui: "How do you expect to win with a power of your size?"

Vegeta: "Hahaha. You rely on your Scouter too much."

Kui: "Pff! What is that supposed to mean?"

Vegeta: "It means I've learned to control my power!!!" *Vegeta powers up.* "Look at my power level with your Scouter now!"

Kui: "Impossible! It's as high as mine!" *Kui becomes terrified as the number increases rapidly.*

Vegeta establishes his supremacy and the number, all by itself, is enough to make Kui take back his death threat and instead offer an alliance against Freeza. But Vegeta is not so easily fooled. As Kui flies away for his life, Vegeta points two fingers at him and makes him explode.

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Why is all of this important? Because what you're witnessing across this arc of the story is Vegeta's transcendence as a man over his former suppressors. The people that tried to keep him down through their own elitist mentalities were conquered by an even *more* elitist attitude and an even *stronger* sense of pride. The difference between them is that Vegeta began to rely on his own internal power, rather than the Scouter, and he actually used the psychology of the Scouter numbers *against* his opponents as if it were a weakness to exploit. Because that's exactly what it was, and it's the reason, along with Vegeta's incredible fortitude, that he was able to win so many fights.

After years of living underneath Freeza's heel and planning his revenge, Vegeta now feels that he's strong enough to take on the overlord. But after a long and drawn out struggle, it turns out that no, he is not. Vegeta

does not wish for immortality. He does not become the Legendary Super Saiya-jin he believed in so strongly. He does not defeat Freeza.

Instead, Vegeta dies from a *ki* blast to the heart after emptying his soul to Goku and tearfully telling his story of a life of servitude. The proud, Saiya-jin prince, cries before a “low class” discard and passes his will of vengeance onto him.

Vegeta is without a doubt a stubborn man, but when he took that *ki* blast to the heart it represented more than a physical death. A part of his very reason for living was given to another. Luckily for Vegeta, Krillin, Gohan and Dende gather the dragon balls and wish him back to life (along with all of the other people killed by Freeza and his men) while Goku battles Freeza. Vegeta dies and is then *born again* before being teleported to Earth via another wish. In many ways Vegeta’s former self died when his heart was pierced, only to be reborn a new man with a new perspective. He just didn’t realize it yet.

Having been teleported to Earth, Vegeta has the understanding that both Freeza and Goku died during the explosion of Planet Namek, and that he is now the most powerful being in the universe. With his greatest enemy and newfound rival dead he is forced to find a new source of motivation. Yet with no one to fight he starts to become comfortable on Earth, going so far as to call it his home. When Goku’s family and friends try to wish Goku back to life they find out that *he is alive after all*, somewhere in outer space!

Vegeta’s motivation returns. His goal? Become more powerful than Goku!!

...

Vegeta represents the part of man that always wants to be better and will not stop until it is achieved. The all-powerful will that rises up against the challenges that serve to keep us down.

Vegeta inspires. That is why he is so adored by fans across the world.

Now let’s take a look at Goku’s worldview and see how his conflicts cause his character in the *Dragon Ball* story to grow.

2.5 Goku Changes Those around Him

Goku is a force of change, both in himself and others. And sometimes Goku is the harbinger of change while other times he is the one forced to adapt. His fight against Vegeta is just one of many instances where conflict comes to Goku unwillingly. He wasn’t asking for trouble. Trouble came to him. The resulting conflicts not only force him to change, but his opponents too.

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2.5.1 Goku meets Raditz! The Violent Clash Begins! Raditz Dies!! Goku Dies!!

Goku's life drastically changes when his long lost brother Raditz decides to have a family reunion. Suffice to say that Goku does not enjoy his first experience being quantified by the Scouter, nor the treatment that his brother gives him as a result. Goku and Raditz are genetically similar, but just as with Vegeta, their upbringing and mentality are worlds apart. Because of this, there are conflicts.

When Raditz arrives on Earth the very first thing he does is check his Scouter to examine the power of the farmer and determine whether or not the citizens of this planet are a threat. With the farmer's power level of 5, he determines they're not. He then checks for other large power sources around the planet. He finds Piccolo instead of Goku, and after being hit by Piccolo's *ki* blast determines that Piccolo is so weak it's not even worth the time to kill him. He locates Goku and flies to his location on Kame Island.

Change comes whether you like it or not, and in this case it came hard and fast. Raditz condemns Goku as weak and soft, ridiculing the fact that he no longer has a tail, the very symbol that makes him a Saiya-jin. In the Viz English edition of *Dragon Ball Z* manga volume 17, Raditz explains their family heritage:

Raditz: "That is because you and I... We are the *same*!! You are no earthling! You are a Saiya-jin warrior... A member of the most powerful race in the universe!!"

Goku: "Shut up!! I don't care if you *are* my brother! I don't care if I *am* an alien!! Krillin was right... People like you are just *wrong*!! I'm Son Goku now!! Get th'heck off my planet!!"

Bulma: You tell 'im Goku!

Kame Sennin: "Nurture over nature, m'boy! Goku's not just an *earthling*... He's th'best dang earthling I know!"

Krillin: "He even *saved* this planet once! So do us a favor an' just *go*, will ya!?"

Raditz provokes him further, knees him in the stomach and then kidnaps his son, Gohan. He gives Goku an ultimatum.

- Option 1: Kill 100 people of Earth and pile the bodies on this Island.
- Option 2: Your son will be murdered.

Raditz says, "If you wish him returned to you *alive*, Kakarot... You will follow my orders... Is that clear? Do it and we fly off together to pile up a few million more bodies. Fail, and there'll be only one dead body... your sons."

Raditz' behavior and reliance on the Scouter shows how the Saiya-jins navigate through life. They use external technology to judge others and guide their self serving decisions. This turns out to be the cause of Raditz's downfall because he did not expect Goku or Piccolo to chase after him together. He did not expect Gohan to strike him in the chest with a rage powered flying head butt. He did not expect Piccolo's *Makankōsappō* (Japanese: 魔貫光殺砲, English: Special Beam Cannon) to be capable of such power.

Why not? Because in his mind, Piccolo, Goku, and Gohan all had a *static* power level. Raditz died as a result of his reliance on the Scouter for the same reasons the aliens died on Namek when fighting Vegeta when he chose to go without one.

Goku dies as well from Piccolo's technique, but it was a willing sacrifice. That was his choice and it's one that saved the planet. As a result he goes to the Other World, trains with North Kaiō in *kaiō ken* (Japanese: 界王拳) martial arts and learns the *genki dama* (Japanese: 元気玉, English: Spirit Bomb) technique.

A year later Goku rushes back to Earth to fight against Nappa and Vegeta.

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2.5.3 Minds and Bodies

Goku's mind becomes so broad and expansive after his recovery from the fight with the Saiya-jins and his subsequent training on board the spaceship to Planet Namek that he could sense and see every living being on the planet.

He arrives on Namek, comes out of his space ship and is able to see all the people *in his mind*. He can actually see them. His sight has gone beyond sight. Forget Scouters. Goku can see everything with such clarity within his own mind that using a Scouter would be a hindrance.

Goku gains this ability through not only his incredible training, but by improving his character and his ability to endure. It's an internal mind-body science that cultivated this ability, and it's something that no one else ever gains, despite undergoing similar training with North Kaiō. So it's not just about achieving a high power level, it's about the unique quality of Goku's character. This ability goes wherever he goes, doesn't require electricity and can't be broken. In Buddha Law cultivation practices it is called the Heavenly Eye (Chinese: *tiānmù*, 天目, Japanese: *tenme*, 天目), or commonly called the Third Eye, as is physically present on Tenshinhan's forehead in *Dragon Ball*.

Goku immediately flies to Gohan's location where he, Krillin and Vegeta are about to die fighting the Ginyu Tokusentai. He then uses another newfound ability to read Krillin's mind and determine what occurred in the past. Goku places his hand on top of Krillin's head and uses retrocognition to see the events unfold in his own mind. He sees the battles they endured, and everything else. How is that possible? Because according to the

traditional East Asian beliefs that *Dragon Ball* is inspired by, everything that occurs in the universe leaves an image and message in time. If the supernatural ability of retrocognition is unlocked, then a person can see past events and the history of other living beings. It's as clear as if you were looking at it directly, and using this ability Goku is instantly brought up to speed without the need for words.

As usual the Ginyu Tokusentai members use the Scouter to determine Goku's power level and then judge his worth. Unfortunately for them, Goku was suppressing his true power. Goku soundly defeats Recoome and Burter with a single blow each. The only ones left are Jeice (whom Vegeta later kills) and Captain Ginyu.

Toriyama uses these quick battles to show Goku's progress while training aboard the spaceship on his way to Namek, and how far he has surpassed Vegeta, who was on the verge of death. He then goes even further beyond by facing off with the leader, Captain Ginyu.

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2.5.4 The Super Saiya-jin Will

Goku stands before a broken man. Vegeta lies in the dirt, pouring out his heart and soul, trying to pass his will and Saiya-jin pride onto the last surviving Saiya-jin, the one he calls Kakarot. The one he believes will fulfill the Super Saiya-jin legend in his place. Not too far away stands Freeza, the overlord who controlled Vegeta's entire life.

Goku doesn't understand what Vegeta and the other aliens have been talking about with all this "Super Saiya-jin" stuff, but to Vegeta it's extremely important, and he goes on and on about it. Why? Because it's why Freeza was afraid and implemented power level judgments at birth. It's why the Saiya-jins were wiped out. *It's why Vegeta struggles so hard.* If Vegeta can become a Super Saiya-jin then he'll be the strongest in the universe and can *enact his revenge*. It's everything he wants in life.

In the Viz English edition of *Dragon Ball Z* manga volume 26, Vegeta struggles to breathe and knows that he is dying:

Vegeta: "Ka... Kakarot... You're still too naïve... too much to be... to be a Super Saiya-jin! B... Be... heartless and cold blooded! Yes... you could become a Super Saiya-jin... if you were more *realistic!*"

Goku: "I can't be heartless like you, and... I didn't understand all your story about the Super Saiya-jins."

Vegeta: "L... Listen well, Kakarot. Planet Vegeta, our mother planet... wasn't destroyed by an asteroid..."

Freeza: "I pierced a hole through his heart... still, he keeps talking?"

Vegeta: "It... It's Freeza who destroyed it. Us Saiya-jins were slaves to him! Except for us they were all exterminated. Your parents, my father, the king... all that because Freeza was afraid of Super Saiya-jins."

Freeza: "Hmph! What's he talking about?"

Finally with his last breath Vegeta reaches the extreme opposite of his prideful nature.

Vegeta: "I... I beg of you! Eliminate Freeza!! Please...! He must die... from the hands... of a Saiya-jin."

The Prince of all Saiya-jins passes away.

Goku: "Vegeta!!!"

Freeza: "He's dead? Not a moment too soon! Can we continue our horrid show?"

Goku takes a moment to give Vegeta a proper burial and continues speaking while laying him into the ground. He says, "You cried. You asked me a favor. I can imagine your rage. It wasn't because all the Saiya-jins died. I get it. You're regretful you were manipulated by Freeza. I hated you, but I must admit you were worthy of the Saiya-jin name. I will follow your advice."

Goku stands up and faces Freeza:

Goku: "I was raised on Earth, but I'm also a Saiya-jin! For all the Saiya-jins and Namek-sei-jin's you killed... I will defeat you!!"

Freeza: "Stop saying such stupid things!"

Goku throws the first punch.

It marks the beginning of a lengthy and grand battle.

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2.6 Vegeta is Multifaceted

The characters in *Dragon Ball* are not black and white, but Scouters make it seem that one person is “better” and the other person “worse.” It simplifies people and equates their value with a number. It puts others into classes and makes the Scouter users’ world a little easier to move around in because they can identify themselves by labeling others. Unfortunately, that mentality is not beneficial for anyone.

The characters in *Dragon Ball* are multifaceted and there are no “bad guys” or “good guys” beyond the roles they play in the story. Just like the rest of us, each person can be viewed from multiple angles and when analyzing a seemingly bad guy such as Vegeta, the more you look at the world from his point of view the more sympathy and understanding you have for his violent behavior. In short, he was a product of his genetics, but even more so his environment.

In an interview with ComicBookResources.com on April 2, 2009, James Marsters, the actor who played Piccolo in the 20th Century Fox live-action Hollywood adaptation called *Dragon Ball Evolution*, answered a question about how he perceives the clashing worldviews in the *Dragon Ball* series. James said, “In Shakespeare, there are really no villains or heroes, there’d just be people behaving in a villainous manner or a heroic manner, and it depends on which chapter of their life you happen to climb in on as to where they fit in the story. And I think that *Dragon Ball* has the same kind of universe where people start really evil and get redeemed in a fairly realistic way. Not like they’re all butter and cookies all of a sudden, but they do switch sides and they do realize certain things. I think that takes it away from white hats and black hats stapled on characters, which is less interesting.”

The most interesting thing about Vegeta isn’t that he grows up in a repressive society built on class struggle and manages to break past it through his own efforts, but that he purposefully projects the repressive society mentality he grew up with onto others. It’s like when a parent beats a child and the child grows up and has their own kids and beats them too. The negative behavior passes onto others.

For example, King Vegeta instilled in Vegeta’s mind that he was better than others, so when fighting Goku he repeatedly talks about how Goku is a “low class” warrior from a “low class” father. He pushes Goku down and builds himself up. But Goku turns that judgment on its’ head and says he’s thankful for it because it allowed him to come to Earth and meet all of his friends. The box can’t hold him.

When that strategy of self validation stops working, then Vegeta talks about how he is superior to Freeza’s men because he no longer needs the Scouter. That sort of backfires and he almost dies fighting Zarbon. So while continuing to say that he is superior he also talks about how he is the Legendary Super Saiya-jin incarnate, and will be the death of all his opponents. This doesn’t come to fruition either, and Goku one ups him again by beating him to that level.

After this he resorts to his all-purpose fallback by calling himself “The Prince of all Saiya-jins,” because surely no one can take that away from him. Despite the fact that according to the canon storyline, Goku is the only full blooded Saiya-jin left in the universe. So is he saying he’s Goku’s prince? No, not really. It’s a proud, boast-

ful statement, an emotional recognition of who he is and where he came from. Even after coming to Earth he still thinks more highly of himself than others.

The root of Vegeta's self-validating statements is a denial of an internal weakness in his character. He makes these external proclamations as a crutch to hold up his own fragile ego in the face of someone better. He holds onto it for as long as he can until it stops working, and then moves onto the next crutch a little bit deeper in his psyche and personal identity.

Vegeta comes from a privileged background and feels he has to uphold that. His identity is centered on the pride that because he was born with these inherent abilities he *should* be better than everyone else. That's the whole source of his identity. Without that, he's nothing. It's actually very fragile and yet this pride is the origin of his power and motivation to constantly be the best. He simply *must* be stronger than Goku. He simply *must* be stronger than Freeza. He simply *must* be stronger than the Artificial Humans. He simply *must* be stronger than Cell, and so on.

Why does Vegeta do this? Because it protects him from facing the truth of his own unhappy, painful life. The fact his father is dead. His partner is dead. His entire race is dead and the only one left is a foolish clown. On top of that he spent the first 30 years of his life unwillingly serving a maniacal despot. It's no wonder he looks so angry!

Vegeta wants happiness just like every man does, and he finds happiness in being the best. But all of his victories and triumphs are short lived because Goku always manages to go one step higher or an opponent appears out of nowhere with more power. His life is poetically sad and bittersweet. Filled with hardship and short lived glory of momentous heights, all in an effort to avoid anguish and find happiness. As a result, Vegeta projects his unhappiness onto others in order to avoid dealing with the pain. In the meantime he chases external goals, always seeking to be better than others and never really achieving the long term validation or self satisfaction he desires.

In comparison to his rival, Goku's genetic father was also killed by Freeza, but Goku was ignorant of that knowledge until he was already an adult, and he, unlike Vegeta, had a positive outlook and nurturing role models from the beginning. Goku later unknowingly killed his own adoptive father, Son Gohan, as a transformed Oozaru, and also spent his remaining teenage years fatherless. But he felt no bitterness and continued to live his life alone in the mountains. He was a happy go lucky country boy without a care in the world (except his next meal). Goku was then raised by one martial arts master after another who treated him with kindness and taught lessons of positivity, tolerance and optimism. He had many father figures who cared for him deeply.

Human beings are meant to grow in a positive and accepting environment but Vegeta's worldview is grounded on a negative and dismissive environment. Such an environment is not conducive to tapping into hidden potential. It leads to constraint, frustration, bitterness and selfishness. That's why Vegeta learned to rely on himself and be consistently derisive of others. So much so that as a child Vegeta had already become heartless and dead inside, not only by slaughtering thousands of innocent people across the galaxy, but by his

complete indifference to the elimination of his own race.

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2.6.1 Blue, Red, and Gold

Goku and Vegeta are rivals because of their difference in perspectives caused by the environment in which they were raised. But at their core they share a mindset that no one else in the cosmos can understand, for they are the last two full blooded Saiya-jins alive. Their similarities ensure their fates are tied together and they help one another develop like the interwoven *yīn* and *yáng* in a *taiji*.

I interviewed Ryo Horikawa, the Japanese voice actor of Vegeta at Anime Expo 2012 in Los Angeles, California. I asked him his thoughts on the rivalry between Goku and Vegeta, and whether or not he felt Dragon Ball was a meaningful series. Ryo said, "I think Dragon Ball is something like the Bible. It has a really important philosophy to it. As far as the rivalry goes, they are sometimes rivals and they also sometimes work together to fight other enemies. I think that helps the story."

Vegeta needs Goku and Goku needs Vegeta because opposites attract and have a mutually beneficial relationship. The *taiji* that is commonly understood consists of black and white *qì* (or *ki*), but that's actually a low level Dao. The higher level Great Primordial Dao talked about in ancient scriptures consists of a blue and red higher energy. Vegeta is blue. Goku is red. One leads, the other follows, and then their roles reverse. They continuously rotate up to higher levels by following the traditional *shugyo* self-cultivation method inherent in East Asian cultural belief systems, where similar events continue occurring at increasingly higher levels with the purpose of refining the practitioner.

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2.6.2 Vegeta Awakens!

To see these concepts in action, let's take a look at *Dragon Ball Z* episode 129, titled "The Might of Vegeta, The Blood of a Super Saiya-jin Awakens." As you can imagine, it is in this episode that Vegeta finally attains his desires.

Vegeta is on Earth fighting against Artificial Human 19 and Artificial Human 20. In the American English dub by FUNimation he delivers a monologue about his newly displayed, shocking power.

Vegeta: "My motivation was very different than Kakarot's. My motivation was to be the *best*. To be the greatest Saiyan alive, as I always had been, until Kakarot came into

the picture, that is."

Vegeta recalls his training in pursuit of overcoming Goku.

Vegeta: "Kakarot's success was like a demon in my head. How could *he* be a Super Saiyan, when *I*, the prince of *all* Saiyans, could not? The intensity of my training was *maddening*. At 450 times normal gravity, a basic training game became a desperate struggle for survival. Even the simplest moves required every ounce of willpower I had. I wasn't sure how long I could sustain the effort without breaking in two. It seemed like the only thing holding my body together was my *one* desire: To be *better* than Kakarot! At times I thought I was *losing my mind*. Why couldn't I obtain what Kakarot had obtained? It didn't make sense. It was infuriating! And it was my *fury* that kept me alive."

Vegeta continues telling his story.

Vegeta: "I decided to continue my training in the solitude of space where I would be unhindered by the distractions of the Earth. And when a violent electrical storm erupted in the skies of the planet I was on, I welcomed it. It seemed fitting, like it was an outward manifestation of the storm that was *raging inside of me!*

A nearby asteroid breaks apart due to the catastrophic planetary storm.

Vegeta: "Then the meteors started coming down, but I was determined to survive and to protect my ship from destruction. It was my *only* way out, my *only* way off that nightmarish heap of rubble. I thought I had everything under control, but then the mother of all meteors seemed to *appear out of nowhere* to claim my ship, and my life. Normally it would have been child's play to blow up that rock, but after training in 450 times normal gravity for so long, it took everything I had, and more!

Vegeta fires a ki blast at the meteor with such power that it causes a part of it to explode, blasting him downward into the planet's surface as the rest of the meteor continues approaching. A moment later Vegeta emerges from the dust, covered in blood. He screams.

Vegeta: "Kakarot!"

The story returns to Vegeta on Earth as he recalls the moment.

Vegeta: "Then something just *snapped*, something *inside* of me."

The story goes back to the planet.

Vegeta: "No. NO MORE! That's it! I don't CARE!"

Vegeta pounds his bloody fist on the ground. His body quakes with anger.

He continues to narrate on Earth as the deadly events unfold on the planet.

Vegeta: "I didn't *care* anymore. I didn't *care* about being better than Kakarot. I didn't *care* about being a Super Saiyan. I didn't *care* if I *lived*. I didn't *care* about *anything*!"

A trigger goes off in Vegeta's mind.

Vegeta: "And then, it happened."

His eyes open wide and he starts screaming as golden light begins to emanate from his body.

Vegeta: "AAAAAAGHHHHHHHHHHHHH!!!"

Vegeta becomes a Super Saiyan as omnidirectional rays of golden light burst out of his body and into outer space.

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2.6.4 *Dragon Ball Inspires*

One of the many reasons why *Dragon Ball* has such a huge fan base is that it inspires. The actions of Goku, Vegeta and the other main characters inspire us to take actions and be more like them. It's a huge part of the *Dragon Ball* fandom. Fans see them "powering up" and *they* want to get powered up. Especially for boys who want to get super huge muscles in the gym or train in the martial arts. But it's not only limited to physical change, or boys for that matter.

On *The Dao of Dragon Ball Blog*, a fan named Monica shared her story of how Vegeta gave her more confidence. Monica said, "I like the tenacity of his character and I identify with him a lot. My favorite thing about Vegeta is that he's not always the best, but he's always trying to be. Vegeta gets kind of a bad reputation, but sometimes charging in guns blazing is the best way to do things, especially if over thinking it is your weakness." A few months after the interview she got a tattoo of the Saiya-jin royal crest on her wrist. She said, "The truth is, I have anger issues mostly due to anxiety and frustration at wanting to accomplish more. I have a tendency to get angry and yell at people or confront them, but all my anger comes from lack of confidence. So yes, I do identify with Vegeta and I relate to his flaws, but I also try to learn from his confidence. I feel like the tattoo will remind me to be more confident." For Monica, *Dragon Ball* is more than just action and fights, it's about connecting with the characters and story. "The reason Vegeta is my favorite is because I think he has the best character development. He's the one that drew me into it." The Saiya-jin royal crest is a symbol of

pride for Vegeta, and for Monica her tattoo serves as a reminder to value her own self worth.

A young man named Joshua also shared his story on *The Dao of Dragon Ball Blog*, saying that he relied on Goku's worldview to help him persevere through a dark valley of life. In 2011, Joshua recently lost his job and had to move back in with his parents. He said, "I was not in a good place. I didn't want to talk to anyone, see anyone, or have anything to do with anything. I had no social life and just sat in my room and stared at the ceiling." Things were not going well and he was depressed and alone. This led to thoughts of suicide.

Fortunately he had *Dragon Ball*.

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2.7 End of Part 2 Sample

Here are the 3 big takeaways of *Dragon Ball* present in the "It's over 9,000!" scene.

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In Part 3 you'll learn how "It's over 9,000!" is a perfect microcosmic slice of the greater macrocosmic story of *Dragon Ball* and why it became so popular across the world.

PART 3 A Thin Slice of *Dragon Ball*

In Part 1 you learned what “It’s over 9,000!” was all about. In Part 2 you discovered the significance of this scene as it relates to the human condition. Now in Part 3 you’ll learn how “It’s over 9,000!” is an example of a meme that represents a small slice of the bigger *Dragon Ball* story, a simple video, image, joke, and phrase that has all the necessary ingredients to shed light on the underlying themes prevalent in the series as a whole. You’ll see that “It’s over 9,000!” represents a single letter in the evolving pop cultural language that is the *Dragon Ball* alphabet. The impact “It’s over 9,000!” had in the *Dragon Ball* community and Internet community is still felt today.

The main reason “It’s over 9,000!” became popular was because of an existing *Dragon Ball* community that is large and global. *Oricon* is a Japanese company that monitors and reports on the sales of entertainment media. On August 7, 2012, *Oricon* released a global report that showed *Dragon Ball* as the world’s most recognized anime and manga among the general public, not just anime fans. The “Over 9,000!” phenomenon was only able to flourish because a community already existed that had the knowledge to understand its meaning and transform it into a meme. In other words it wouldn’t have gone viral unless there were people out there who “got it.” Without those people who shared the clip with others it would have simply been one of the other countless funny videos that hits the Internet and falls flat.

Dragon Ball is filled with rich history, eastern influences, pop cultural references, fairy tales, legends and beliefs that continue to inspire generations of children and young adults today. It is but one of many spin-off phenomena within the larger *Dragon Ball* phenomenon that has occurred over the years such as the most recent “Super Saiyan’s are Real” video. So what made “It’s over 9,000!” so successful?

Thanks to the Internet there is now a reactive relationship between content creators and content consumers. It’s no longer a 1-to-many relationship as has been the case in previous decades and media. It’s now a 1-to-many-to-community cycle. That means one person creates something and it reaches other people, who then repurpose or alter it slightly while adding their own personal stamp and then share it with others again. This is the nature of an Internet meme and likewise the nature of a sub culture focused community like the one *Dragon Ball* fans belong to. When you have both, the meme spreads like wildfire, evolves rapidly, and is able to reach outside the sub culture.

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Symbols and Stories

The East Asian languages of Chinese and Japanese that *Dragon Ball* is derived from have an inherent characteristic at telling stories. Their written language, *kanji*, is an image based language, as *kanji* are illustrated im-

ages within images that contain meaning. An individual *kanji* can consist of other independent *kanji* that each denote their own meaning, and when combined denote a subtler connotation or greater meaning, creating the basis for language.

Manga is the natural evolution of this form of communication because it is a medium filled with illustrations. The illustrations themselves tell a story, but so do the words, written in *kanji*, *hiragana* and *katakana*. The action sound effects written across the page also tell a visual story as representations of sounds.

The profound importance of all this is that the images or phrases are devices used individually to tell a story and collectively to tell an even greater story. This holds enormous power as a form of communication. Whenever an image or concept tells a story it becomes a powerful language and vehicle of communication. When you combine this with animation and audio in the form of anime it becomes even more powerful. Adding interactivity, such as in the form of a video game causes a big impression on the one who experiences it, such as when FUNimation dubbed the lines again for *Dragon Ball Z: Burst Limit*. The collective story behind the manga, the anime, and the Internet meme as described in this e-book is all recollected by the player when playing the game, along with their expectation to watch the “It’s over 9,000!” scene, and this causes the moment to be more engaging and memorable. In this sense the *Dragon Ball* world collides with our world through the meme.

Human beings have an innate longing to identify themselves within a community. Like many aspects of *Dragon Ball*, “It’s over 9,000!” is just one example of how this pop cultural force became a part of an emerging language and urban slang. Aside from being useful it helps others identify with one another and connect. It pulls into our human need to communicate and belong; to be part of the in-joke or popular sayings. When “It’s Over 9,000!” is spoken across the Internet by two people who understand it, they are immediately on common ground.

This e-book has shown that just like the written *kanji* characters of Japan, the symbolism and characteristics of “It’s over 9,000!” can be dissected further down into smaller stories. The stories and meaning are what matter most, because these are what make the deepest impact on our language and thereby in ourselves.

Micro and Macro

The microscopic lens I’ve shined on “It’s over 9,000!” is purposeful, in what it says about the *Dragon Ball* series as a whole.

Although “It’s over 9,000!” is a small segment, it contains all of the elements of *Dragon Ball Z*. The short clip has extremely muscular guys in martial arts uniforms, supernormal powers, spiky hair, screaming, explosions, references to ancient beliefs, futuristic technology, and underlying themes of the human condition.

“It’s over 9,000!” subsequently became a new linguistic term that can be spoken, heard as audio, appear as

an image, watched as video, worn as clothing, set up as action figures or played as a game. That is to say, this culture must be established for there to be genuine transformation in an individual, and it is through being influenced by this culture that an individual gains the ability to transform the culture back. Every time a new message is created and put on the Internet, or any other medium, it has the power to change lives. Even a message that seems simple or lacking in power can have a big effect when accepted, modified, and shared infinitum. "It's over 9,000!" is the perfect example of a simple message in the right context that was born from a culture and then changed that culture.

As a common part of the Millennial Generation's vernacular and Internet slang, "It's over 9,000!" affects people in subtle yet profound ways. One's language becomes part of their identity. To fully understand a culture you have to know its language, whether it's Chinese, Japanese, French, Italian, or "Internet," because without knowing the language you can't know the heart, spirit and culture of the people who speak it. For all of the people who say "It's Over 9,000!" on the Internet or in real life, their language, self-identity and social relationships have been altered. How much and in what ways depends on the individual.

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Yet when something new is introduced into the *Dragon Ball* community that becomes viral it can alter the way people look at the series. Such as how Team4Star's incredibly popular satirical videos on YouTube made Mister Popo seem creepy and weird. If you say the words "Pecking order" to a *Dragon Ball* fan who is also a fan of those videos it means much more and is a lot funnier than saying, "a social hierarchy." The fans understand the characters so well that they can make in-jokes about other in-jokes, playing off the subtle relationship queues and odd moments. The language and the series itself become much richer replacements to the words that we normally use because now they're loaded with imagery, humor, and associations with the characters that fans have come to love.

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End of Part 3 Sample - Only a Thin Slice

In the same way that "It's over 9,000!" is a thin slice of the entire *Dragon Ball* series, this e-book is but a thin slice of what you will find in *The Dao of Dragon Ball* book. This entire e-book was derived from about 1 minute of content from the series, but within this 1 minute there are so many meaningful insights that were revealed when you examined fully.

The entire *Dragon Ball* series that Akira Toriyama draws upon to create his masterpiece is rich in centuries of history, culture, and the message of the human condition. He draws on all these elements and makes them his own unique creation.

In *The Dao of Dragon Ball* I go into further detail about all of the underlying themes, including the martial arts

cultures, religion, spirituality, character backgrounds, and conflicts in the series. I reveal the hidden elements, the complex interweaving of culture, history and storytelling, and in a sense decipher this code, this alphabet that is "*Dragon Ball*." Shedding light on how it becomes a very powerful new and influential pop cultural language. You will understand why the *Dragon Ball* series is the most popular anime and manga of all time. You'll find out where the Son Goku legend originates, how Goku compares to Superman, what the Japanese think of their own creation, how anger plays a role in the process of enlightenment, and so much more.

I will show you how profound stories can teach people and shape their lives to the point where it becomes the very reason they want to live. People resonate with *Dragon Ball* because it connects to the human spirit. If you're a lover of *Dragon Ball*, then you'll love to read *The Dao of Dragon Ball*.

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Next Steps ...

Buy Dragon Ball Z “It’s Over 9,000!” When Worldviews Collide

[The Dao of Dragon Ball Website](#) has this e-book available for sale on the Buy the Book page, and it can also be purchased at Amazon, Apple, Kobo, and other major e-book retailers, including independent stores.

The full e-book will reveal further insights, history, and fascinating connections to ancient martial arts principles and spiritual beliefs. It also discloses the impact “It’s Over 9,000!” had throughout the world, and the inner meaning of the #1 action anime series of all time.

Read The Dao of Dragon Ball Blog

[The Dao of Dragon Ball Blog](#) is written to share insights on *Dragon Ball* and have discussions with fans. Join in!

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Write to the Author

If you have questions or comments about this e-book, be sure to write Derek at:

<http://thedaofdragonball.com/>



Derek Padula is the author of *The Dao of Dragon Ball*, the first book to reveal the deep history, philosophy and ancient cultural roots of the world's #1 anime and manga.

Derek has been a fan of *Dragon Ball* since 1997 when he first watched the anime, and has seen every episode and read every chapter of the manga dozens of times. His love for *Dragon Ball* inspired him to begin martial arts training in Shaolin Gong Fu, and then Taiji Quan, Qi Gong, San Sau, Shotokan Karate, and Falun Dafa meditation. Derek earned his B.A. in East Asian Studies and a minor in Chinese from Western Michigan University. He studied abroad in Beijing, China where he trained with the Buddhist Shaolin Monks and a Daoist Taiji Sword Master.

He loves to design video games, speak at anime conventions, and wants to share his understanding of this profound series that continues to influence the lives of millions.